Verbal Hygiene

Marc Alexander · Week 8

Who decides how we ought to speak?

1. The LPA toolbox

Transitivity

Modality

Presupposition

Semantics

2. Settle these arguments

- What is the plural of *octopus*: *octopuses*, *octopi* or *octopodes*?
- Is this right? "I literally died laughing."
- At the checkout: "10 items or less" or "10 items or fewer"?
- Is *irregardless* a word?
- Is *rizz* a word?

Verbal Hygiene

3. Prescriptive and descriptive

- **Prescriptive**: statements about how language should be used
- **Descriptive**: statements about how language is used

> The plural of *octopus* should be *octopuses*.
> Most people in this room said *octopi*.

4. Verbal hygiene

> "[Verbal hygiene is the] motley collection of discourses and practices through which people attempt to 'clean up' language and make its structure or its use conform more closely to their ideals of beauty, truth, efficiency, logic, correctness and civility."
>
> Cameron (2012: vii)

5. Six ideals

Beauty

Truth

Efficiency

Logic

Correctness

Civility

[1]

6. Everyone does it

- campaigning for the use of plain language on official forms
- belonging to a spelling reform society, a dialect preservation society or an artificial language society
- going for elocution lessons
- editing prose to conform to a house style
- producing guidelines on non-sexist language, or opposing such guidelines
- schoolchildren cruelly mimicking a classmate's 'posh' accent
- workers who institute a 'swear box' and fine one another for using 'bad language'[2]

7. Linguists do it too

- Hall, Robert A., Jr. 1950. *Leave your language alone!*

> "For change that comes spontaneously from below, or within, our policy should be, Let your language alone, and leave its speakers alone! But other forms of language manipulation have other origins, other motives, other effects, and are far more dangerous."
>
> Lakoff (1990: 298)

Says Who?

8. The Académie française



FIGURE 1 The Institut de France on the Quai de Conti in Paris: a domed classical building with two curved wings, under a clear blue sky

- Founded 1635
- 40 members, *les Immortels*; motto "À l'immortalité"
- The ninth edition of its dictionary was completed in November 2024
- Begun in the 1980s; the previous edition was 1935; more than 53,000 entries

9. Quebec: the OQLF

Recommended until 2017	Accepted since 2017
coquetel	*cocktail*
sandwich au fromage fondant	*grilled cheese*
coup d'écrasement	*smash*
pain grillé	*toast*

3

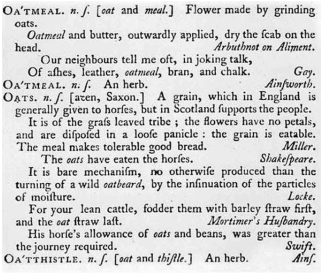
10. English never got an academy

- Dryden, Defoe and Swift all proposed one
- Swift, *A proposal for correcting, improving and ascertaining the English tongue* (1712)

> "to enchain syllables, and to lash the wind, are equally the undertakings of pride"

Johnson, Preface to the *Dictionary* (1755)

11. Johnson's *oats*



OA'TMEAL. *n. ſ.* [*oat* and *meal.*] Flower made by grinding oats.
Oatmeal and butter, outwardly applied, dry the ſcab on the head. *Arbuthnot on Aliment.*
Our neighbours tell me oft, in joking talk,
Of aſhes, leather, *oatmeal*, bran, and chalk. *Gay.*
OA'TMEAL. *n. ſ.* An herb. *Ainſworth.*
OATS. *n. ſ.* [æten, Saxon.] A grain, which in England is generally given to horſes, but in Scotland ſupports the people.
It is of the graſs leaved tribe; the flowers have no petals, and are diſpoſed in a looſe panicle: the grain is eatable. The meal makes tolerable good bread. *Miller.*
The *oats* have eaten the horſes. *Shakeſpeare.*
It is bare mechaniſm, no otherwiſe produced than the turning of a wild *oatheard*, by the inſinuation of the particles of moiſture. *Locke.*
For your lean cattle, fodder them with barley ſtraw firſt, and the *oat* ſtraw laſt. *Mortimer's Huſbandry.*
His horſe's allowance of *oats* and beans, was greater than the journey required. *Swift.*
OA'TTHISTLE. *n. ſ.* [*oat* and *thiſtle.*] An herb. *Ainſ.*

FIGURE 2 A column of Johnson's 1755 Dictionary in eighteenth-century type, with the entries oatmeal, oats and oatthistle; oats reads: 'A grain, which in England is generally given to horses, but in Scotland supports the people.'

> "A grain, which in England is generally given to horses, but in Scotland supports the people."

Johnson (1755), s.v. *oats*

12. *Webster's Third* (1961)

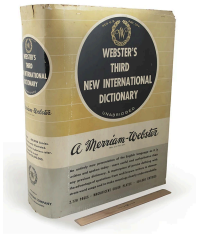


FIGURE 3 The 1961 Webster's Third New International Dictionary, Unabridged, a thick volume in a cream and black dust jacket with the Merriam-Webster logo

- Philip Gove's *Webster's Third New International Dictionary* recorded how people used words, with fewer labels such as *slang* or *nonstandard*, and an entry for *ain't*

> "surrendered to the permissive school"

The New York Times, editorial, 12 October 1961

13. The reviews

- *The New York Times* parodied the new dictionary: "A passel of double-domes at the G. & C. Merriam Company joint in Springfield, Mass., have been confabbing and yakking for 27 years"
- Wilson Follett, *The Atlantic*, January 1962: "a very great calamity"
- In Rex Stout's *Gambit* (1962), Nero Wolfe burns his copy, page by page

> "untuned the string, made a sop of the solid structure of English"

Dwight Macdonald, "The String Untuned", *The New Yorker*, 10 March 1962

14. Take but degree away

> Take but degree away, untune that string,
> And hark, what discord follows! Each thing meets
> In mere oppugnancy: the bounded waters
> Should lift their bosoms higher than the shores,
> And make a sop of all this solid globe.

4

15. The American Heritage Usage Panel

- The *American Heritage Dictionary* (1969) answered *Webster's Third* with a Usage Panel of 105 writers, editors and scholars
- 11 of the 105 were women; 6 were under 50
- Panellists voted on ballots of example sentences; the editors turned the results into usage notes
- Nearly 200 members by the end; dissolved on 1 February 2018

e·nor·mi·ty (ĭ-nôr′mĭ-tē) *n. pl.* **e·nor·mi·ties. 1.** The quality of passing all moral bounds; excessive wickedness or outrageousness. **2.** A monstrous offense or evil; an outrage. **3.** *Usage Problem.* Great size; immensity: *"Beyond that,* [Russia's] *sheer enormity offered a defense against invaders that no European nation enjoyed"* (W. Bruce Lincoln). [French *énormité*, from Old French, from Latin *ēnormitās*, from *ēnormis*, unusual, enormous. See ENORMOUS.]

USAGE NOTE: *Enormity* is frequently used to refer simply to the property of being enormous, but many would prefer that *enormousness* (or a synonym such as *immensity*) be used for this general sense and that *enormity* be reserved for a property that evokes a negative moral judgment: *Not until the war ended and journalists were able to enter Cambodia did the world really become aware of the enormity of Pol Pot's oppression.* Fifty-nine percent of the Usage Panel rejects the use of *enormity* in the more general sense in the sentence *At that point the engineers sat down to design an entirely new viaduct, apparently undaunted by the enormity of their task.* This distinction between *enormity* and *enormousness* has not always existed historically, but nowadays many observe it. Writers who ignore it in phrases such as *the enormity of the President's election victory* or *the enormity of her inheritance* may find their words an unintended source of amusement.

FIGURE 4 *American Heritage Dictionary of the English Language*, 3rd edn (1992), s.v. *enormity*

16. The panel changes its mind

Example	Usage Panel
to contact someone	acceptable to 34% (1969), 65% (1988), 94% (2004)
"The Philharmonic will *premiere* works by two young Americans"	acceptable to 14% (1969), 51% (1987), 77% (1999), 84% (2008)

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Example	Usage Panel
"*Hopefully*, the treaty will be ratified"	acceptable to 44% (1969), 27% (1992), 34% (1999), 63% (2012)
"I only had a moment to *peruse* the manual quickly"	unacceptable to 66% (1988), 58% (1999), 48% (2011)

[5]

17. Settling the arguments

Question	Authority	Answer
octopus	Fowler, ed. Burchfield (1998: 539–540)	"The only acceptable pl. in English is *octopuses*."
literally	Merriam-Webster	figurative use since 1769
irregardless	*OED*; Merriam-Webster	a word, in "nonstandard or humorous use" (*OED*); attested since 1795
rizz	Oxford University Press	Oxford Word of the Year 2023; a clipping of *charisma*

18. Rees-Mogg's office rules (2019)

- Leaked to ITV News in July 2019, when he became Leader of the House
- Banned: *very*, *due to*, *equal*, *lot*, *got*, *hopefully*, *I am pleased to learn* and others
- Imperial measurements; a double space after a full stop; *Esq.* for men without a title

19. GOV.UK: words to avoid

"Plain English is mandatory for all of GOV.UK so avoid using these words:"

- *deliver*: "pizzas, post and services are delivered - not abstract concepts like improvements"
- *key*: "(unless it unlocks something)"
- *slim down*: "(unless talking about one's waistline)"
- *drive out*: "(unless it's cattle)"
- *going/moving forward*: "(it's unlikely we are giving travel directions)"[6]

20. "Up to 10 items"



FIGURE 5 Three checkout signs side by side: '10 Items or less' in Tesco's colours, a green sign reading 'Baskets only, 10 items or fewer', and a Tesco sign reading 'Up to 10 Items' over a row of tills

- 2008: Tesco replaced "10 items or less" with "Up to 10 items"
- The Plain English Campaign said this "avoids any debate"

Unparliamentary Language



FIGURE 6 The empty chamber of the House of Commons: green benches on either side, the Speaker's chair at the far end, a red line on the carpet in front of each front bench

"Good temper and moderation are the characteristics of parliamentary language."

Erskine May, *Parliamentary practice*. Photo: Wikimedia Commons

21. Words the Speaker has ruled out

- *blackguard*
- *coward*
- *git*
- *guttersnipe*
- *hooligan*
- *humbug*
- *ignoramus*
- *liar*
- *Pharisee*
- *pipsqueak*
- *rat*
- *stool pigeon*
- *swine*
- *traitor*

- Erskine May printed a list of expressions ruled unparliamentary until its 20th edition (1983) dropped it
- Current Commons guidance: "There is no hard and fast list of unparliamentary words"

22. Sent out of the Chamber

Date	MP	Said	Outcome
11 April 2016	Dennis Skinner (Labour)	"dodgy Dave"	ordered out for the day
31 January 2022	Ian Blackford (SNP)	Johnson had "wilfully misled Parliament"	ordered out
20 April 2026	Lee Anderson (Reform)	Starmer had "been lying"	ordered out
20 April 2026	Zarah Sultana (Your Party)	"bare-faced liar"	named; suspended for five days

23. Getting round the rule

> terminological inexactitude
> economical with the truth
> inadvertently misled the House
> couldn't lie straight in bed

24. Lord Teverson in the Lords



FIGURE 7 House of Lords, 2018. Footage: parliamentlive.tv (video)

25. What Lord Teverson said

Verbatim

"Can we actually make it clear here that I haven't heard one word around this chamber of anybody that says please Her Majesty's Government don't do anything until um we've you know un-un-until this-this-this thing has finished. […]"

Hansard

"Can we actually make this clear? I have not heard anyone in this Committee saying, "Please, Her Majesty's Government, do not do anything until this thing is finished". […]"

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26. Hansard's house style

- Correct "this" to "the", and remove other deictics
- Correct "this chamber" to "this Committee" or "this House"
- Omit otiose repetition ("very very")
- Remove otiose hedges such as "I believe" and "I think"
- Government is always plural

Accents, Dialects and Scots

27. Banned in school

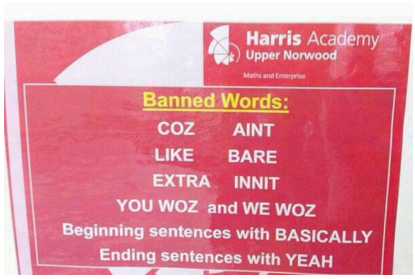


FIGURE 8 A red sign headed Harris Academy Upper Norwood, 'Banned Words': COZ, AINT, LIKE, BARE, EXTRA, INNIT, YOU WOZ and WE WOZ, beginning sentences with BASICALLY, ending sentences with YEAH

- A classroom whiteboard (US, 2024): *skibidi*, *rizz*, *gyatt*, *edging* and others
- *6-7*: Dictionary.com's Word of the Year 2025, banned by US teachers, and top of Lake Superior State University's 2026 Banished Words List

28. Glasgow

- A university lecturer: "The accent of the lowest state of Glaswegians is the ugliest one can encounter."
- 40 pupils at Lochend Secondary, Easterhouse: 88% rated /hus/ (*house*) as slang, 75% as Scots

Judged "incorrect"	Before a discussion of Scots	After
An urny gaun tae bed	50%	13%
She knoaked a boa'le over iz heid	60%	20%

8

dreich, glaikit, hoose, peely-wally

29. In the *Dictionary of the Scots Language*

Word	Sense	Record
dreich	"dreary, cheerless, bleak" (of weather)	from 1721
glaikit	"Senseless, foolish"	from c1475
hoose [hus]	"Sc. forms of Eng. *house*"	1702 to 2004
peelie-wally	sickly, pale, ill-looking	from 1833

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30. The Scottish Languages Act 2025



Scottish Languages Act
2025

2025 asp 10

FIGURE 9 Title page of the Scottish Languages Act 2025, asp 10, with the royal arms of Scotland above the title

- Passed on 17 June 2025 with no votes against; Royal Assent on 31 July 2025
- Gaelic and Scots official languages of Scotland from 30 November 2025
- 2022 census: 2,444,659 people with some Scots skills; 130,161 with some Gaelic

Verbal Hygiene for Positive Ends?

31. Plain language

> Take two tablets 4 hourly

32. *autistic person*, *person with autism*

- **Identity-first**: *autistic person*
- **Person-first**: *person with autism*
- A UK survey of 3,470 people: autistic people preferred *autistic person*; professionals favoured *person with autism* (Kenny et al. 2016)

33. "Political correctness"

– "The avoidance of forms of expression or action that are perceived to exclude, marginalize, or insult groups of people who are socially disadvantaged or discriminated against" (*Oxford Dictionary of English*)

> "It is worth considering why critics of PC readily say that it is PC to suggest that adult females should be referred to as 'women' and not 'girls', but do not see it as PC when 'bank accounts' are relabelled 'financial products'."
>
> Fairclough (2003)



FIGURE 10 Anonymous leaflet, Clapham, 1970 general election; Lambeth Archives, ref. 05422

34. Who is cleaning up whose language?

When	Who	What
2025	US federal agencies	more than 250 words and phrases removed or flagged on government websites, including *women*, *disability* and *Gulf of Mexico*
July 2025	West Northamptonshire Council (Reform UK-led)	staff asked to remove references to "net zero" and to say "environmental impact" for "climate impact"
August 2025	Merton Council	press reports of a ban on *mum and dad*; the chief executive: the council "has not stopped the use of the term"
September 2026	Green Party	terminology guidance, as reported: *parents and carers*; avoid *elderly*, *able-bodied*

10

35. Swearing and slurs

– Discriminatory language is more problematic for audiences than swearing
– Terms about race, nationality and ethnicity are among the least acceptable
– Intent is one of the strongest influences on what is acceptable
– The watershed is still seen as an important safeguard[11]

36. Platforms and machines

unalive

A euphemism for *kill* or *die* on TikTok and similar platforms, to avoid moderation; American Dialect Society Euphemism of the Year 2021

ducking

iOS 17 (2023) stopped autocorrecting the obvious swear word

The em dash

From 2025 taken as a sign of AI writing, and removed by writers who did not want to look like machines

delve

At least 13.5% of 2024 PubMed abstracts were processed with LLMs, found through sudden rises in style words (Kobak et al. 2025)

37. Being told what to say

Case	Who tells whom	How	Whose identity is in the words
Harris Academy (2013)	a school, its pupils	a rule on the wall	the speaker's own
Glasgow classrooms	a teacher, pupils	discussion of Scots	the speaker's own
The Speaker	the Chair, MPs	withdraw or leave	the person spoken about
Merton Council (2025)	a council, its staff	a guide, reported as a ban	the people spoken about
Green Party (2026)	a party, its members	guidance: "okay to make mistakes"	the people spoken about

38. Better and worse ways

– **Subtractive**: a new variety replaces the old one; **additive**: a new variety is added to the speaker's repertoire (Lambert 1974)
– **Face**: the public self-image a speaker wants to keep; a correction threatens it, more so in public (Brown & Levinson 1987)
– **Linguistic insecurity**: speakers who believe their own speech is wrong (Labov 1966)
– Glasgow pupils' judgements of Scots sentences as "incorrect" fell after a discussion of Scots
– Cushing (2020): school bans discourage pupils from speaking at all

39. The LPA toolbox, today

Tool	Today's examples
TRANSITIVITY	words and phrases "removed or flagged" on US government websites

Tool	Today's examples
MODALITY	"Plain English is mandatory"; "The only acceptable pl. in English is *octopuses*"
PRESUPPOSITION	"Is *irregardless* a word?"; *inadvertently* misled the House
SEMANTICS	*terminological inexactitude*; *coloured*; *autistic person*, *person with autism*

40. Verbal hygiene, again

Beauty

Swift's *Proposal* (1712)

Truth

Hansard's "substantially the verbatim report"

Efficiency

GOV.UK's words to avoid

Logic

fewer items; *Up to 10 items*

Correctness

school banned-word lists

Civility

the Speaker's banned words; Ofcom's ratings

41. Reading

- Cameron (2012), chapter 1, "On verbal hygiene" (pp. 1–32)
- Optional: Milroy & Milroy (2012); Cushing (2020); Curzan (2024)

Notes

1. Cameron (2012: vii)
2. Cameron (2012: 9)
3. *Le Devoir* and *National Post*, 19 September 2017
4. Shakespeare, William. c.1602. *Troilus and Cressida*. Act I, scene iii.
5. *American Heritage Dictionary* usage notes
6. GOV.UK style guide, A to Z, "Words to avoid"
7. House of Lords, February 2018
8. Janet Menzies, STELLA, University of Glasgow
9. *Dictionary of the Scots Language* (dsl.ac.uk): *SND*, *DOST*
10. PEN America; *Byline Times*, 23 July 2025; *LocalGov*, 11 August 2025; *The Spectator*, 30 September 2026
11. Ipsos for Ofcom, *Public attitudes towards offensive language on television, radio and video-on-demand*, October 2026

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